PROJECT PLANNING PHASE

Incident Lifecycle Automation in ServiceNow

Agile Planning | Product Backlog | Sprint Schedule | Velocity | Tracker | Burndown

Project Name	Incident Lifecycle Automation in ServiceNow
Document Name	Project Planning Phase
Phase	Project Planning Phase
Date	08 September 2026
Team ID	
Maximum Marks	5 Marks

1. Planning Approach

The project is planned using Agile/Scrum concepts. Large functional areas are treated as Epics, and each Epic is divided into User Stories (USN). Story Points use the Fibonacci-style values 1, 2, 3 and 5 to estimate relative effort. The backlog in this document is a project-planning estimate; actual completion values should be updated after execution.

1.1 Purpose of Project Planning

Incident Lifecycle Automation in ServiceNow covers many connected activities, from service setup to incident resolution and knowledge capture. Project planning is necessary to define this work clearly, decide the order in which it is built, estimate the effort required, and set a realistic schedule. A written plan also gives the team a common reference for monitoring progress and for checking that every lifecycle activity is covered before final validation.

1.2 Planning Methodology

Agile/Scrum is applied by splitting the project into short, time-boxed sprints. Each sprint delivers a usable group of incident-management features, and progress is reviewed against the plan at the end of each sprint. The Agile terms used in this document are summarised below.

Agile Term	How It Is Used in This Project
Epic	A major functional area of the project, such as Incident Classification or Resolution & Closure.
User Story (USN)	A small, testable requirement written from the user's point of view and identified as USN-1 to USN-11.
Story Point	A relative measure of the effort and complexity of a user story.
Sprint	A fixed six-day work period. The project has two sprints: Sprint-1 and Sprint-2.
Product Backlog	The complete prioritised list of user stories (Section 2).
Project Tracker	A status table used to monitor each epic across the two sprints (Section 5).

1.3 Planning Objectives

- **Break the project into functional epics:** group related incident-management capabilities into clearly named areas.
- **Divide epics into user stories:** describe each requirement as a small task that can be built and tested.
- **Estimate effort using story points:** assign relative effort values of 3 or 5 to each story.
- **Assign work to sprints:** distribute the 35 planned points across Sprint-1 (15) and Sprint-2 (20).
- **Track project progress:** use the sprint schedule and project tracker to record the status of each epic.
- **Monitor planned and actual completion:** compare planned values with actual values after each sprint is completed.

1.4 Sprint Planning Strategy

The sprints follow the natural order of the incident lifecycle. Later activities depend on the records and configuration created earlier, so core setup is completed first and advanced activities are completed afterwards.

Sprint	Focus and Reason
Sprint-1	Core incident setup and handling (USN-1 to USN-5). Service and Service Offering setup, incident creation, classification, knowledge-assisted troubleshooting, and assignment/escalation form the foundation that every later activity depends on.
Sprint-2	Advanced incident lifecycle activities and validation (USN-6 to USN-11). Level 2 investigation, Emergency Change linkage, Child Incident management, resolution and closure, and Knowledge Article creation build on Sprint-1. Final validation and testing is placed last so that all features can be checked together.

2. Product Backlog, Sprint Schedule and Estimation

2.1 Story Point Estimation

Story points express the relative effort and complexity of a user story, rather than a number of hours. A story with 5 points is expected to need more effort, testing and coordination than a story with 3 points. Fibonacci-style values (1, 2, 3, 5) are used because the gaps between them widen as work becomes larger and less certain, which discourages false precision and makes the team choose clearly between small and large estimates. In this project, the stories for individual features are estimated at 3 points, and the final validation and testing story is estimated at 5 points because it covers many records and deployment testing.

2.2 Product Backlog

The backlog lists every user story with its epic, sprint, estimate and priority. The Team Members column is left blank for the team to complete.

Sprint	Functional Requirement (Epic)	User Story Number	User Story / Task	Story Points	Priority	Team Members
Sprint-1	Service & Incident Setup	**USN-1**	As a Service Desk Agent, I want to create a Service and Service Offering, so that incidents can be associated with the correct service.	**3**	**High**	_____
Sprint-1	Incident Management	**USN-2**	As a Service Desk Agent, I want to create an Incident Record with the required incident information, so that the issue is formally logged and can be tracked.	**3**	**High**	_____

Sprint	Functional Requirement (Epic)	User Story Number	User Story / Task	Story Points	Priority	Team Members
Sprint-1	Incident Classification	**USN-3**	As a Service Desk Agent, I want to classify an incident using Category, Subcategory, Urgency, Service and Configuration Item, so that it is prioritised and routed correctly.	**3**	**High**	_____
Sprint-1	Knowledge & Agent Assist	**USN-4**	As a Service Desk Agent, I want to use Knowledge Management and Agent Assist, so that I can find relevant troubleshooting information quickly.	**3**	**High**	_____
Sprint-1	Assignment & Escalation	**USN-5**	As a Service Desk Agent, I want to reassign or escalate an incident to the appropriate support group when required, so that it reaches the team able to resolve it.	**3**	**High**	_____
			Sprint-1 total planned story points	**15**		
Sprint-2	Level 2 Support	**USN-6**	As a Level 2 Technician, I want to investigate an escalated incident and track the investigation details, so that the root cause can be identified and recorded.	**3**	**High**	_____
Sprint-2	Change Management	**USN-7**	As a support stakeholder, I want to create and relate an Emergency Change Request when an incident requires urgent change activity, so that the change is linked to the incident it supports.	**3**	**Medium**	_____
Sprint-2	Parent/Child Incidents	**USN-8**	As a Service Desk Agent, I want to create and relate a Child Incident, so that recurring or related issues can be tracked.	**3**	**Medium**	_____
Sprint-2	Resolution & Closure	**USN-9**	As a Service Desk Agent, I want to document Cause, Resolution, Resolution Details and closure information before resolving or closing the incident, so that the outcome is fully recorded.	**3**	**High**	_____
Sprint-2	Knowledge Management	**USN-10**	As a support stakeholder, I want to create a Knowledge Article from useful resolution information, so that it can help resolve future incidents.	**3**	**Medium**	_____

Sprint	Functional Requirement (Epic)	User Story Number	User Story / Task	Story Points	Priority	Team Members
Sprint-2	Validation & Testing	**USN-11**	As a project team member, I want to validate the incident, service, SLA, change, child incident, knowledge and related records and perform deployment testing, so that the solution is confirmed to work as intended.	**5**	**High**	_____
			Sprint-2 total planned story points	**20**		
			Total planned story points (Sprint-1 + Sprint-2)	**35**		

Total planned story points: 35 (Sprint-1 = 15; Sprint-2 = 20).

3. Sprint Schedule

The project is scheduled as two six-day sprints. Sprint start and planned end dates are fixed in the plan. The last two columns are for recording actual results after each sprint and are intentionally left as "To be recorded".

Sprint	Total Story Points	Duration	Sprint Start Date	Sprint End Date (Planned)	Story Points Completed (as on Planned End Date)	Sprint Release Date (Actual)
Sprint-1	15	6 Days	08 Sep 2026	13 Sep 2026	To be recorded	To be recorded
Sprint-2	20	6 Days	15 Sep 2026	20 Sep 2026	To be recorded	To be recorded

3.1 Sprint Objectives and Planned Workload

Sprint	Objective	User Stories	Planned Points	Planned Dates
Sprint-1	Set up the service and handle core incident activities: creation, classification, knowledge-assisted troubleshooting, and assignment/escalation.	USN-1 to USN-5	15	08–13 Sep 2026
Sprint-2	Complete advanced lifecycle activities (Level 2 investigation, Emergency Change, Child Incident, resolution and closure, Knowledge Article) and perform final validation and testing.	USN-6 to USN-11	20	15–20 Sep 2026

3.2 How the Schedule Is Tracked

- **Sprint duration:** each sprint is planned for 6 days.
- **Planned workload:** Sprint-1 carries 15 story points and Sprint-2 carries 20 story points.
- **Actual completion tracking:** the story points actually completed by the planned end date are entered in the "Story Points Completed" column after each sprint.
- **Release-date tracking:** the date on which each sprint is actually released is entered in the "Sprint Release Date (Actual)" column. Planned end dates are targets and are not actual completion dates.

4. Velocity Calculation

Velocity is the amount of work, measured in story points, that a team completes in one sprint. It is used to judge whether the planned workload is realistic. The planned values for this project are calculated below.

Item	Calculation	Result
Planned total story points	15 + 20	35
Number of planned sprints	Sprint-1 and Sprint-2	2
Planned average velocity	Total Story Points / Number of Sprints = 35 / 2	**17.5 points per sprint**
Planned average rate for a 6-day sprint	17.5 / 6	≈ 2.92 points per day
Planned rate – Sprint-1	15 / 6	2.5 points per day
Planned rate – Sprint-2	20 / 6	≈ 3.33 points per day

4.1 Planned Versus Actual Measures

Term	Meaning
Planned average velocity	An estimate based on the planned backlog (35 / 2 = 17.5). It is a planning figure and is not measured team performance.
Story points completed	The points of user stories that are fully finished within a sprint. To be recorded after each sprint.
Actual team velocity	Story points completed divided by the number of completed sprints. It can only be calculated after completed sprint work has been recorded.
Sprint performance	A comparison of story points completed with story points planned for each sprint (Sprint-1: 15 planned; Sprint-2: 20 planned).

Note: This is a planning velocity based on the estimated backlog. Actual team velocity should be calculated from story points completed after the sprints.

5. Project Tracker

The project tracker summarises each epic with its user stories, planned points, sprint and current status. It lets the team see at a glance which work belongs to each sprint and update the status as work moves forward. All totals agree with the product backlog in Section 2.

Epic	User Stories	Planned Points	Sprint	Status
Service & Incident Setup	**USN-1, USN-2**	6	Sprint-1	Planned
Incident Classification	**USN-3**	3	Sprint-1	Planned
Knowledge & Agent Assist	**USN-4**	3	Sprint-1	Planned
Assignment & Escalation	**USN-5**	3	Sprint-1	Planned
Sprint-1 total		**15**	Sprint-1	
Level 2 Support	**USN-6**	3	Sprint-2	Planned
Emergency Change	**USN-7**	3	Sprint-2	Planned
Child Incident	**USN-8**	3	Sprint-2	Planned
Resolution & Closure	**USN-9**	3	Sprint-2	Planned
Knowledge Article	**USN-10**	3	Sprint-2	Planned
Validation & Testing	**USN-11**	5	Sprint-2	Planned
Sprint-2 total		**20**	Sprint-2	
Total planned story points		**35**		

5.1 Status Categories

The current status of every epic is Planned. As work progresses, the status can be updated using the following categories.

Status	Meaning
Planned	The work is in the backlog and assigned to a sprint, and has not started.
In Progress	Work on the user story has started but is not finished.
Completed	The user story has been finished and checked against its purpose.
Blocked	Work cannot continue until a dependency or issue is resolved.

6. Planned Burndown Chart

The chart below is a planned burndown for the 35-point backlog. It represents expected remaining work over the two 6-day sprints and is not an actual execution result.

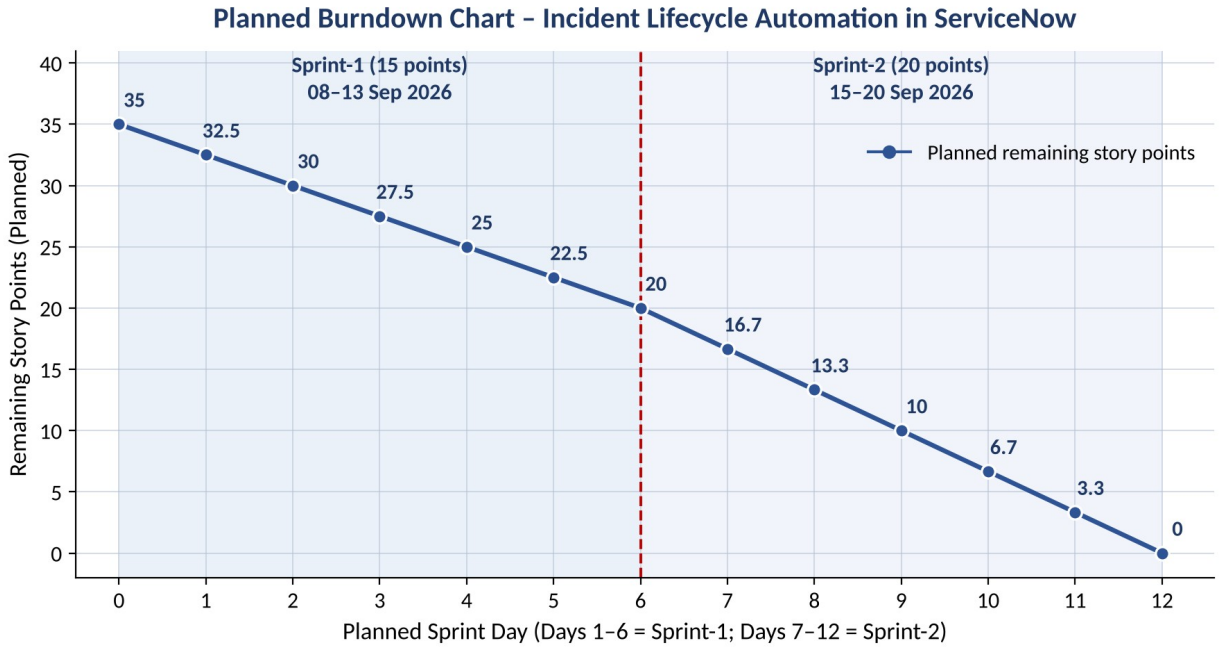


Figure 1: Planned burndown of 35 story points across Sprint-1 and Sprint-2

6.1 How to Read the Chart

- **Starting point:** the line starts at 35 remaining story points before any work begins (Day 0).
- **Sprint-1 (Days 1–6):** the 15 planned points are burned down at 2.5 points per day, leaving 20 points at the planned end of Sprint-1 (13 Sep 2026).
- **Sprint-2 (Days 7–12):** the 20 planned points are burned down at about 3.33 points per day, reaching 0 points at the planned end of Sprint-2 (20 Sep 2026).
- **Ending point:** zero remaining story points means the full planned backlog is complete.

This is a planned (ideal) burndown. No actual daily progress is shown. An actual burndown line can be added after sprint work is recorded.

7. Planning Summary

The backlog covers the complete Incident Lifecycle Automation workflow: service and service offering setup, incident creation and classification, knowledge-assisted troubleshooting, escalation to Level 2, emergency change linkage, child incidents, resolution and closure, knowledge article creation, and final validation/testing. Sprint-1 focuses on setup and core incident handling, while Sprint-2 completes advanced lifecycle activities and validation.

Sprint-1 (15 points, 08–13 Sep 2026) builds the foundation: the service and service offering, the incident record, its classification, knowledge-assisted troubleshooting, and assignment or escalation. These steps let an incident be logged, understood and passed to the right team.

Sprint-2 (20 points, 15–20 Sep 2026) completes the lifecycle: Level 2 investigation, an Emergency Change where urgent change is needed, Child Incidents for related issues, documented resolution and closure, and a Knowledge Article so the solution can be reused. Final validation and testing then confirms that all related records work together.

7.1 Lifecycle Coverage

Lifecycle Activity	User Story	Planned Sprint
Service and Service Offering setup	**USN-1**	Sprint-1
Incident creation	**USN-2**	Sprint-1
Incident classification	**USN-3**	Sprint-1
Knowledge-assisted troubleshooting	**USN-4**	Sprint-1
Assignment and escalation	**USN-5**	Sprint-1
Level 2 investigation	**USN-6**	Sprint-2
Emergency Change linkage	**USN-7**	Sprint-2
Child Incident management	**USN-8**	Sprint-2
Resolution and closure	**USN-9**	Sprint-2
Knowledge Article creation	**USN-10**	Sprint-2
Final validation and testing	**USN-11**	Sprint-2

Together, the two sprints cover all 11 user stories and 35 planned story points of the Incident Lifecycle Automation project.